

Olivia Chartrand

Miranda Horton

Megan Jordan

LIS 4000 Foundations of Library, Archival, and Information Science

2024, August 18

The Rainbow Reading Club

Community Profile:

According to research done by the UCLA in 2020, approximately 9.5% of the American population ages 13 - 17 identify as on the LGBTQ+ spectrum with 0.73% identifying as transgender specifically (Conron, 2020). That is roughly 3.2 million young people who identify as part of the LGBTQ+ community here in the United States (Conron, 2020). Only 26.4% of youth aged 13 - 17 are out to all of their immediate and able to live their lives authentically, however, despite the rise in social acceptance and growth of the queer community across the US, members of the LGBTQ+ community still struggle to feel safe (Human Rights Campaign, 2023). Nearly 60% of youth who sought mental health care in the last year were unable to find access, 28% of queer youth are reportedly homeless, and 18% of the queer population ages 13 - 17 attempted suicide in 2023 (The Trevor Project, 2024). The population of youth in America that identifies as LGBTQ+ is one that is physically, mentally, and emotionally at risk as they struggle and find support and community.

Needs and Strengths:

A sense of community and support is incredibly important for LGBTQ+ youth due to the immense scrutiny and marginalization they face across the country. Young people in the LGBTQ+ community are more likely to face bullying and violence and engage in substance

abuse, they make up a large population of the homeless youth population, and are more likely to attempt suicide than their peers. One study in Massachusetts found that queer students have a variety of unmet needs including mental health support, inclusive discussions of sexual health and education, safe spaces, and affirmation and guidance during gender transition (Sava et al., 2021). Federal research also shows, “youth are coming out at younger ages than previous generations” but despite general societal acceptance the risk of familial disapproval leads some queer youth to run away from home (Mitsdarffer et al., 2023). Unhoused LGBTQ+ youth report abuse, neglect, rejection, and lack of acceptance as reasons for leaving their family homes (Cunningham et al., 2014). Young queer people, especially those that are school aged, are a group in need of support and community.

Despite the many factors working against queer youth, they are resilient, adaptable, and passionate. As the digital age progresses queer teens are finding communities online, seeking assistance from any available resource, and fighting for the creation of safe space in their schools (Robinson & Schmitz 2021). They work hard for the spaces that they have made and, as they age, become a force of political power holding rallies and advocating for themselves across the country. Queer youth create a fierce, protective community when they are given the opportunity to feel safe and it is one of their greatest strengths.

About the Project:

The Chandler Public Library hosts The Rainbow Reading Club, which will be a space for LGBTQ+ identifying teens to read stories they can relate to, seek support in group forums, and find community resources and safe spaces. The club itself will meet virtually once a month with a different book assigned for discussion at each meeting. The books will cover the wide range of LGBTQ+ identities with a different theme each week to provide a variety of queer perspectives

for the members and readers to connect with. Discussions will be led by a librarian and a representative from a local LGBTQ+ support organization, therapist, social worker, or school guidance counselor. In addition to regular book discussions, an online forum will be available for youth to chat with each other and support professionals

Due to this being a virtual club, teens will be encouraged to access the reading materials through the Libby reading app and use technology from home to attend the virtual meetings. Space and technology will be made available at the library for those who do not have the technology access at home. The only required financial burden of the club will be to pay for a video subscription program to host the virtual meetings and should come from the youth programming budget. The Rainbow Reading Club will be promoted on social media and through flyers posted around popular community buildings.

Goal:

The goal of the Rainbow Reading Club program is to provide a safe and supportive space for teens who identify as part of the LGBTQ+ community. As our research shows, queer youth are socially neglected and often left feeling isolated, leading to a host of mental health issues, homelessness, and substance abuse (Cunningham et al., 2014). Our club seeks to combat this isolation by providing a sense of community through reading and online forums. By meeting virtually and messaging in monitored, safe online forums, youth have the opportunity to sign on from anywhere with an internet connection. They can chat with others going through similar experiences and make friends in an environment designed for them. Through reading, the participants can see depictions of their lives and characters in situations they can relate to and discussions of these books can lead to interpersonal connection.

Through book discussions, online forums, and a list of community aid organizations, queer youth will have the support that is lacking in many other places in their lives. With involvement with LGBTQ+ organizations we can create a positive impact on the lives of young people by connecting them with life saving resources and places to turn to when they are feeling isolated and unsupported. Our goal is to provide queer youth with a place to be their authentic selves and a community that supports them.

Rainbow Reading Club Website: <https://megankayjordan.wixsite.com/lis-4000-book-club>

References

- Conron, K.J. (2020) LGBT Youth Population in the United States. *The Williams Institute*.
<https://williamsinstitute.law.ucla.edu/publications/lgbt-youth-pop-us/>
- Cunningham, M., Pergamit, M., Astone, N., & Luna, J. (2014). Homeless LGBTQ youth.
Washington, DC: Urban Institute. Retrieved from:
<https://www.urban.org/research/publication/homeless-lgbtq-youth>
- Goldberg S. K., Lewis T., Kahn E., Watson R. J. (2023). 2023 LGBTQ+ Youth Report. *Human Rights Campaign Foundation*. hrc.org/youthreport2023
- Hilton, K., Siegel-Stechler, K., Medina, A., de Guzman, P., Searles, S. (2024) . “Queer Youth Are Powerful, Diverse, and Engaged-but Struggling with Mental Health.” *Circle at Tufts*, Retrieved from:
circle.tufts.edu/latest-research/queer-youth-are-powerful-diverse-and-engaged-struggling-mental-health#:~:text=Of%20the%20queer%20youth%20in,%2C%20and%208%25%20as%20asexual
- The Trevor Project. (2022, December 15) 2022 national survey on LGBTQ Youth Mental Health.
<https://www.thetrevorproject.org/survey-2022/>
- Mitsdarffer, M. L., McColl, R., Nescott, E., Bianchetta, J., Layland, E. K., & Tóth, T. (2023). LGBTQ+ Youth Homelessness in Delaware: Building a Case for Targeted Surveillance and Assessment of LGBTQ+ Youth Needs and Experiences. *Delaware Journal of Public Health*, 9(2), 80–86. <https://doi.org/10.32481/djph.2023.06.014>
- Robinson, B.A., Schmitz, R.M. (2021) Beyond resilience: Resistance in the lives of LGBTQ youth. *Sociology Compass*. <https://doi.org/10.1111/soc4.12947>

Sava, L. M., Earnshaw, V. A., Menino, D. D., Perrotti, J., & Reisner, S. L. (2021). LGBTQ Student Health: A Mixed-Methods Study of Unmet Needs in Massachusetts Schools. *The Journal of School Health*, 91(11), 894–905. <https://doi.org/10.1111/josh.13082>